

Caste Oppression and Womens' Subordination in Jaffna

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We see everywhere violent destruction, gaping tears in the fabric of our society, the abandoning of many of our cherished values and the collapse of many institutions of which we were once proud. Our people have been brutalised by several years of civil war in which many thousands of the population, mostly young girls and boys, have been killed and immeasurable damage has been done to public and private property. The economy has been devastated. The military presence which significantly intruded into Jaffna in the late fifties and from time to time thereafter has greatly increased and spread through the length and breadth of this island. We are now confronted with an intimidating array of diverse armed forces. Some parts of our country including Jaffna have been virtually unpoliced for many years and the courts have ceased to function in those districts. Civil authority has been greatly undermined. Numerous public, private and non-governmental institutions have all but disappeared and much of civic life has ground to a halt.

Jaffna society has been often described as conservative and even reactionary. There is much truth in this. There has been some belated improvement but caste prejudice continues to be strong in Jaffna. In this respect the Jaffna Tamil Community is perhaps the most backward in Sri Lanka. Even the Christian schools have done very little to combat this evil. What is the proportion of the so called depressed caste student in Jaffna's leading Christian schools compared to that in the population of the district? How many teachers do they have from those communities? Do they have any programmes to promote integration

or to reduce disparities in socioeconomic levels?

Jaffna women also suffer restrictions but in this matter the evidence is mixed. In the Hindu as in the Greek pantheon the 'portfolio' of education is held by a woman, presumably the most learned of the deities. Despite the status of Saraswathi and of Athene as the Goddess of Learning there have been many obstacles to the educational advancement of women. Some of these barriers are being lowered in Jaffna as elsewhere. In fact the people of this region were among the first to respond to the new opportunities for education that emerged under British rule. Some of the finest and the earliest of the modern girls schools of South Asia were established in Jaffna. Since then girls schools have multiplied and expanded. Schools like Chundikuli have produced thousands of girls who have gone on to excel in higher education in Sri Lanka, India and many other countries.

But there continues to be a disparity between boys and girls in the encouragement and motivation provided by many of the parents and several of the schools in respect of selection of subjects of study and choice of careers. While boys are encouraged to take subjects which will equip them for high-prestige careers, girls are often encouraged to opt for subjects which are intellectually less demanding and career-wise less promising. Despite such bias it is a matter of pride that in certain highly competitive fields, e.g. admissions to Sri Lanka's Medical Schools, girls have secured almost as many places as boys. In this respect we are ahead of the USA and many other developed countries in which the gender-disparity in Medical Schools is greater. Girls have succeeded

in staking a strong claim for parity in educational opportunities and, despite some handicaps, have shown that given equal facilities they can do as well as, or even better than boys.

However, society continues to impose many restrictions on women in respect of employment. In this matter we have been slower to lower barriers against women than many developed countries. Even within the professions to which women are admitted they tend to be pushed into certain functions and specialities and away from certain others. Women may be encouraged to get involved in religious work but are largely denied the status and functions of priesthood. Within the medical profession they may be encouraged to specialise in obstetrics and gynaecology rather than general surgery. Women engineers tend to do desk jobs with prospects of career advancement inferior to that of their male colleagues. In the legal profession women are numerically disproportionate in chambers headed by male lawyers or assist male advocates rather than head their own chambers or conduct their own cases in the courts. Once excluded from the Ceylon Civil Service, women are now admitted to the Sri Lanka Administrative Service but, to the best of my knowledge, only one of them has been posted as a Government Agent and none has risen to be the Secretary of a Cabinet Ministry.

Such obstacles to the professional advancement of women exist to a greater or less extent in all countries. All over the world we find women concentrated in teaching, nursing, library science, secretarial work, social work, certain types of factory work, the garment industries etc. None would claim that these occupations are unsuitable for women. What I am suggesting is that women can greatly widen their horizons and enter and excel in hundreds of other professions which are now largely the preserve of men. I have no doubt that such developments will be encouraged by this school.

(Speech at Chundikuli Girls School.)

Some may protest that the environment is not conducive to such venturing out along new avenues of activities. They may urge that women must stick to safe and well-trod professional fields till settled conditions are restored. Feminists, who are no doubt well represented in this school, may urge that it is precisely because conditions are unsettled that there are new opportunities which should be seized. There is indeed much evidence from many countries to support such an assertion. For example Franz Fanon writes of the transformation in the status of women during the Algerian revolution: "The woman who before the Revolution never left the house without being accompanied by the mother or the husband is now entrusted with special missions... she spends the night with an unknown family... the husband or the father learns to look upon the relations between the sexes in a new light".

There have been some such developments in our society in the last few years. I do not want to be misunderstood. I am not suggesting that women should take needless risks. Nor am I endorsing their involvement in violent activities which I consider to be suitable neither to women nor to men. All I am saying is that under revolutionary situations, such as during the French Revolution two centuries ago, or during the Egyptian or Indian independence struggle half a century ago or in the current Palestinian Intifada, some of the obstacles to the activities of women may be removed and they may gain opportunities to exercise certain freedoms or to advance in new career fields. Such openings may not come their way under more settled conditions. Similarly in times of rapid economic and cultural transformation, as in South India in the Sangam period, in the USA for many decades and in many countries in the early post world war 2 years, women may occupy key positions from which they were previously excluded and exercise freedoms

they were traditionally denied. A large proportion of the writers and poets of the Sangam period were women, notably Avvai whose advice on government was sought by the kings of that period. Some of the gains may become permanent but some may be lost when the special conditions conducive to such gains disappear. In some respects Tamil women have not fully regained the freedoms they exercised during the Sangam period nor French women the status they enjoyed during the French Revolution.

The extraordinary conditions which now prevail may provide fresh opportunities for women to advance. To a limited extent we saw, in the eighties, women's groups taking important initiatives in public affairs in various parts of our country. Moreover, with a large proportion of the male population killed, disabled, detained, engaged in military activities, gone overseas or otherwise unable to be active in public life women are needed more than ever before to occupy key positions. Some progress has been made. We need to advance further and to consolidate the gains. We are in a critical period in our history. Many are apprehensive of our future and the society of tomorrow. Let us hope that women will have a major role in determining that future, in creating the institution of that society, in establishing its values and in the conduct of business and the public services in the years to come.

I have spoken of what women in general are called upon to do. But what do others expect of the women and little women of Chundikuli? As an old pupil and also as an old boy of St. Johns, I may claim to have some insights into this question. Many schools have Latin mottos which the students do not even understand, let alone live up to. Your motto is Forward, which is also the theme of your Collage song. It could mean that you are called upon to be in the vanguard, on the frontier, of every advance. The

Collins New Concise Dictionary also defines Forward as presumptuous, pert and impudent. I believe that the common perception, particularly among Johnnians, is that the girls and old girls of Chundikuli are forward in every sense of that word. I urge you to be true to your motto. Those who know the girls and old girls of Chundikuli are aware that they do not really need such prompting to assume leadership roles. Some may even think that what is needed is a word of caution. But submitting to undue restraint, keeping out of the centre of activity and failing to meet challenges are not in the spirit of Chundikuli.

I would urge the girls of Chundikuli to be bold and ambitious in your choice of subjects of study and adventurous and idealistic in your career aspirations. Do not feel constrained by the traditional limitations placed by others on your scholastic and professional careers. Several of those who have passed through this school have distinguished themselves in fields which were once but are no longer regarded as more suitable for men. I have no doubt that many among you will do the same and blaze new trails along which others will follow. I am not thinking only of the white collar professions but of every kind of community service which requires imagination, special skills, dedication to duty, strength of character and leadership qualities.

Perhaps by the turn of this century many among you will occupy key positions in various public and community services, in banking, in industry and commerce, in academic and in political life. Perhaps some of you will become outstanding philosophers, archeologists, electronic engineers, artists, architects, mathematicians, scientists, marine engineers, explorers, authors, economists, journalists, broadcasters, drama and film producers, actors, airline pilots and stewards, industrialists, marketing managers, diplomats

and political leaders. I have listed some professions at random not so much as occupations I recommend but rather as indicating the range and variety of career prospects open to a young woman with a modern education such as Chundikuli provides. You have as much right as anyone else to set your sights high and your school equips you better than most others to reach those targets. But I trust that your aspirations are not directed exclusively on the elite professions and that your ambitions are not narrowly defined in terms of social prestige and economic status.

It is important to keep several factors in mind. Firstly, only a small minority of students can enter the elite professions. The large majority will occupy positions of less prestige and lower remuneration. It is as much the function of the school to prepare and motivate girls to serve in these positions as to equip the few who may move into occupations higher up the social ladder. Secondly, job-satisfaction and opportunities to make a significant contribution to public welfare may be found as much outside as within the elite professions. Mahatma Gandhi was eminently qualified to be a successful barrister. He got far more job-satisfaction and made an incomparably greater contribution to society by abandoning that career for unpaid political and community service. Many of the missionaries including several who served in this district were well equipped for distinguished professional careers in their own country. They gained, and we all gained, because they chose instead to engage in even more valuable, and demanding but virtually unpaid, service in land far distant from their place of birth. Subramaniam Barathi with the advantages of Brahmin birth and exceptional intellectual and literary skills, could have found a place at the apex of Indian society. He preferred to align himself in his lifestyle and the content of his poetry

with the poor and oppressed of that subcontinent; our civilization is much richer on that account.

It is not only people of the stature of Mahatma Gandhi, Subramaniam Barathi, Florence Nightingale, Vinobha Bhave, Albert Schweitzer and Mother Theresa who can gain job-satisfaction through deviating from lucrative traditional or professional career tracks. If we look around we can see many men and women at every social level who greatly contribute to the happiness of others and gain much job-satisfaction in doing so. You may find such people both in your school and outside in many walks of life. They may be teachers, clerks, minor employees, nurses, attendants, shop-keepers, salespersons, bus drivers, conductors, government servants, municipal employees, voluntary workers in non-governmental organizations or neighbours, not all of whom may have regular employment. Creative energy, high motivation to help others and satisfaction in doing one's duty well are needed and are to be found in all sectors and at all levels. To the extent that a society places excessive emphasis on gaining high academic qualifications, entering the elite professions and enjoying economic affluence in assessing the worth of its members, it contributes to the frustration of the majority who may have other goals or who fail to reach the targets set by that community. That population also fails to make the best use of its human resources. Perhaps we can trace back much of the ills of our society to the false values to which we have all contributed.

Perhaps among you there are many who aspire to be social and community workers, whether full time or part time. Perhaps large numbers among you will opt to work with women's groups, with the physically, mentally or socially handicapped and with the poor. I trust that whatever your social status may be in the years to come, you will engage in

combating class and caste prejudices, ignorance, corruption-poverty, violence and other social evils, and champion human rights. Let us hope that the stature of this school will grow not only through producing the social elite but also through inspiring, motivating and equipping girls and old girls to transform our society. Any school can produce pupils and old pupils who aspire to join the elite professions and move up the social ladder. Not all schools inspire students with higher motivation. I trust that Chundikuli will provide such inspiration and that it is those so motivated who will lead the way forward to our future. I thank you for giving me the privilege of addressing you and for your patient hearing.

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events have proved too volatile to be restrained to above framework. Regrettably, we know what it means to cope with the heady aftermath of this. And in such circumstances, I ask those who keep speaking about the phantom of civil war and make people used to thinking about it, those who are whipping up confrontation in society and between ethnic groups, those who sow the seeds of intolerance and hatred and who have turned the "enemy image" into a steadily traded commodity whether they realise where all this will take them. Or is theirs deliberate attempt to cause chaos and disintegration?

It is necessary to act in keeping with common sense: power must advance reform in all walks of life, paving the way for society's cohesion and acting firmly to uphold the law. Deliberations appealing to populist sentiment and abuse of democracy and Glasnost can only stir up trouble and incite destructive action.

Where then will it take us? One ought to know our history well to engage in politics in such a country as ours,

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